

BENCHMARKING DISCOVERY & COMMERCIAL DEFINITION PHASE

Benchmarking Agent

Benchmarking Service

Product Requirements Document (PRD)

Prepared for	Executive Management, Product and the Development team
Purpose	Define the scope, analysis types, sector KPIs, client inputs, agent outputs and the MVP versus Premium offer
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1. Summary

The Benchmarking Agent tells a client how its performance compares with a relevant group of peers, where the biggest gaps are, and what better performers do differently. It works from the client's own figures and from approved external sources. Every external number in a report carries its source, and the agent never uses competitors' confidential data.

Benchmarking is an established management discipline. Robert Camp of Xerox described it in his 1989 book as "the search for industry best practices that lead to superior performance" [1]. Today it is sold at every scale: enterprise programmes from APQC, The Hackett Group and Gartner [23][31][32]; mid-market competitive-intelligence platforms [33][34]; financial ratio books and reports for smaller firms [24][35]; and free benchmark reports published by SaaS investors and lenders [11][12][13]. In June 2026 Xero added industry benchmarks to its accounting software for small businesses [36].

What this means for the product

Basic financial ratio comparison is becoming a free feature inside accounting software. Our offer has to win on four things the research shows clients value: the right peer group, sector-specific KPIs, a clear explanation of each gap, and a practical plan, with every number traceable to its source.

4

benchmarking types
classified

3+1

sector KPI sets plus a
cross-industry core

2

packages: MVP and
Premium

0

confidential competitor
figures used

Recommendation

- **MVP:** performance benchmarking against an aggregated industry peer group, plus internal benchmarking of the client's own units or years. Three sectors (retail, SaaS, manufacturing) and a cross-industry financial core. Delivered as a report, a KPI scorecard and a data file.
- **Premium:** adds named-competitor comparison from public data, practice benchmarking (functional and generic), finer peer segmentation, multi-year trends, a presentation deck, periodic refresh and an analyst review.

Decisions requested

1. Approve the scope and non-goals in Section 3.
2. Approve the MVP and Premium split in Section 11 as the basis for pilot pricing tests.
3. Commission a legal review of the guardrails in Section 10 before any client pilot.

2. What benchmarking is, and how the market delivers it

2.1 Definitions and method

Spendolini describes benchmarking as "the continuous and systematic process of evaluating the products, services or processes of organizations that are recognized as representative of best practices for purposes of organizational improvement" [43]. APQC, a non-profit benchmarking body, structures every study in four phases [4]:

APQC phase	What happens	Who does it in our service
Plan	Choose the focus area, key measures and definitions	Client and agent together (intake)
Collect	Gather quantitative and qualitative data, internal or external	Agent, from approved sources and client data
Analyze	Understand the gaps and why best performers do better	Agent, with analyst review
Adapt	Build an improvement plan with progress tracking	Agent proposes; the client implements

2.2 Two ways to classify benchmarking

APQC separates **what** is compared from **who** it is compared against [2][3]. Performance benchmarking compares quantitative measures; practice benchmarking looks at how the results are achieved. On the second axis, the standard types are internal, competitive, functional and generic [3]. The classic functional example is Xerox studying the warehouse order-picking of L.L. Bean, an outdoor-clothing mail-order retailer, to improve its own logistics [6].

2.3 How benchmark results are presented in practice

Provider	How results are shown	What we take from it
APQC Open Standards Benchmarking	Gap analysis against top, median and bottom performers; more than 2,000 measures [23]	Show the client against quartiles, not only an average
The Hackett Group	"World-class" defined as the top quartile on efficiency and effectiveness [31]	Use the top quartile as the stretch target
RMA Annual Statement Studies	19 ratios across 640+ industries (NAICS), arrayed by asset and sales size [24]	Peer groups must be cut by size, not only industry
Benchmarkit (SaaS)	Filters by company size, contract value, go-to-market motion, region [13]	Segment SaaS peers by business model
Xero Industry Benchmarks	Cohorts by industry and country; growth, profitability, debtor days, cost-to-income [36]	This is the free baseline we must exceed

3. Core definition: problems solved and scope

3.1 Problems the agent solves for the client

Client question	What the agent provides	Package
"Are we doing well or badly?"	The client's position against the peer median and quartiles for each KPI	MVP
"Where is our biggest gap?"	Gaps ranked by size and, where the data allows, by financial value	MVP
"Are our targets realistic?"	Targets anchored to the peer median and top quartile	MVP
"Which of our units performs best?"	Internal comparison of sites, units or years	MVP
"How do we compare with named rivals?"	Comparison using the rivals' public filings and public information only	Premium
"What do better performers do differently?"	Practice findings from published research, cited	Premium

3.2 Where it sits in our service ecosystem

The Macroenvironment Agent (Phase 2) describes the economy a client operates in. The Benchmarking Agent describes how the client performs against peers inside that economy. Both share the same rule: no invented figures. A proposed interface, to be confirmed in architecture, is that benchmarking reuses the macro agent's verified exchange rates and inflation figures when it converts currencies or adjusts periods.

3.3 Out of scope (non-goals)

Naming non-goals explicitly is standard practice in PRDs [38][39]. The agent will not:

- Collect, receive or use competitors' non-public data, or act as a channel for exchanging data between competitors [5][9][10].
- Recommend prices based on competitors' prices or pricing data [10].
- Pool one client's confidential data into another client's benchmark (see Section 10).
- Run primary research on other companies: site visits, interviews or consortium surveys.
- Provide real-time competitor monitoring. Dedicated competitive-intelligence platforms already serve that need [34].
- Give investment, legal, tax or audit opinions, or value companies.
- Implement improvements. It proposes a plan; the client owns execution.
- Benchmark a sector that has no approved KPI set and source list (Section 5.7).

4. Analysis typology: what the agent can run

The matrix below combines APQC's two axes [2][3]. Each cell shows whether the agent offers that analysis and in which package.



Figure 1. Benchmarking typology and package coverage

Type	Question it answers	Data the agent uses	Package
Internal	Which of our units, sites or periods performs best, and by how much?	The client's own data only	MVP
Competitive: peer group	How do we compare with similar firms in our industry?	Aggregated industry data from official and licensed sources (Section 9)	MVP
Competitive: named rivals	How do we compare with specific competitors?	Rivals' public filings and other public information	Premium
Functional	How does our function (for example finance or logistics) compare with the same function in other industries?	Cross-industry process measures, such as those built on the APQC Process Classification Framework [22]	Premium
Generic	What can we learn from any organisation about a broad process?	Published practice research, cited	Premium (practice only)

Performance benchmarking (numbers) is the MVP's core because it can be automated with sourced data. Practice benchmarking (how and why) depends on qualitative research, so it sits in Premium and always carries citations.

5. Industry segmentation: peer groups and sector KPIs

5.1 How a peer group is built

A benchmark is only useful if the peers are comparable. The agent builds every peer group from four dimensions, each drawn from how established providers segment their data.

Dimension	How it is set	Evidence
Industry	Official classification code: NAICS (North America) or NACE (EU). The client's description is mapped to a code and confirmed	RMA uses NAICS [24]; Eurostat uses NACE [29]
Size	Revenue or asset band, and employee count where available	RMA arrays by asset and sales size [24]; the Census QFR reports by asset size [25]
Region	Country first; wider region only if country data is too thin	Xero cohorts by industry and country [36]; World Bank Enterprise Surveys by economy [30]
Business model	For SaaS: contract value and go-to-market motion. For retail: store-based or online	Benchmarkit filters [13]; SaaS Capital shows retention varies with contract value [12]

Minimum peer count

Every benchmark shows how many peers it is based on. Below a minimum count the agent does not publish the figure and says why. The threshold will be set in architecture with legal input, because aggregation that prevents identifying any single firm is also a competition-law expectation [9].

5.2 Cross-industry core KPIs (all sectors)

KPI	What it shows	Where peer data comes from
Revenue growth	Pace of growth versus peers	Public filings [27]; Xero cohorts (SMB) [36]
Gross, operating and net margin	Pricing power and cost control	RMA [24]; Census QFR [25]; Damodaran industry margins [28]
Gross operating rate	Operating surplus as a share of turnover	Eurostat structural business statistics [29]
Labour productivity	Value added per person employed	Eurostat [29]
Debtor days (DSO)	How fast customers pay	RMA [24]; Xero [36]
Current ratio, debt ratios	Liquidity and balance-sheet strength	RMA [24]; Census QFR [25]

5.3 Retail

KPI	Definition	Published reference or source
Comparable (same-store) sales growth	Sales growth of stores open at least 12 months, versus the same period last year	Company filings [27]
GMROI	Gross profit ÷ average inventory at cost [45]	Client data; peer filings
Inventory-to-sales ratio	Inventory held relative to monthly sales	Census Monthly Retail Trade Survey [17]
Shrink	Inventory lost to theft, damage or error, as % of sales	NRF: average 1.6% in FY2022, up from 1.4% [16]
E-commerce share of sales	Online sales as % of total sales	US: 17.1% of retail sales in Q2 2026 [44]
Online cart abandonment	Share of online carts not completed	Baymard: 70.22% average across 50 studies [18]
Sales per square foot	Annual sales ÷ selling space	Company filings [27]

5.4 SaaS (software as a service)

KPI	Definition	Published reference or source
ARR growth	Year-on-year growth in annual recurring revenue	KeyBanc/Sapphire 2025: median expected to rise from 15% (2024) to 20% (2025) [11]
Net revenue retention (NRR)	Revenue kept from existing customers including upsell, minus churn and downgrades	SaaS Capital 2025: median 101% for private B2B SaaS, down from about 117% in 2021 [12]
Gross revenue retention (GRR)	As NRR but without upsell; cannot exceed 100%	KeyBanc/Sapphire: around 90% [11]
CAC payback	Months of gross profit needed to recover the cost of acquiring a customer	KeyBanc/Sapphire survey [11]; Benchmarkit [13]
Burn multiple	Net cash burn ÷ net new ARR over the same period	Defined by David Sacks (Craft Ventures) [14]
Rule of 40	Revenue growth % + profit margin % should be at least 40	Widely used investor test [15]

5.5 Manufacturing

KPI	Definition	Published reference or source
Overall equipment effectiveness (OEE)	Availability × performance × quality	85% is the commonly cited "world-class" level from Nakajima's Total Productive Maintenance [19]
First pass yield	Share of units made right first time, without scrap or rework	MESA's 28 manufacturing metrics [21]
On-time delivery to commit	Share of orders delivered on the date committed	MESA [21]
Manufacturing cycle time; changeover time	Order release to finished goods; time to switch products	MESA [21]
Capacity utilisation	Output used as a share of total capacity	MESA [21]
Financial ratios by industry	Margins, returns, balance sheet	Census Quarterly Financial Report [25]; Census Annual Integrated Economic Survey [26]

Operational KPI definitions follow ISO 22400-2, the international standard for manufacturing operations KPIs [20]. Peers rarely publish operational figures such as OEE, so the MVP compares these against published reference levels (clearly labelled as such) or runs them as internal benchmarking across the client's own plants.

5.6 KPI coverage by sector

KPI family	Retail	SaaS	Manufacturing
Growth	Comparable sales	ARR growth	Revenue growth
Profitability	Gross margin, GMROI	Gross margin, Rule of 40	Gross and operating margin
Efficiency	Sales per sq ft, inventory-to-sales	CAC payback, burn multiple	OEE, cycle time
Customer	Cart abandonment, e-commerce share	NRR, GRR	On-time delivery
Quality / loss	Shrink	Churn (within GRR)	First pass yield
Financial health	Core ratios (5.2)	Core ratios (5.2)	Core ratios (5.2)

5.7 Adding a new sector

A new sector goes live only when it has: a KPI set with written definitions, at least one approved peer data source per KPI, a peer-group rule, and a test run reviewed by an analyst.

6. Client inputs

If a mandatory input is missing or unclear, the agent stops and asks. It never fills a gap with a guess.

6.1 Mandatory

Input	Why it is needed	Validation
Industry	Selects the KPI set and peer data	Mapped to a NAICS or NACE code; client confirms
Country or region	Selects regional peers and currency	Must have peer data available
Company size	Builds a like-for-like peer group	Revenue band; employees if available
Objective and benchmarking type	Decides internal versus peer comparison and the KPI focus	One of the types offered in the package
Period	Aligns client and peer data in time	Fiscal year(s); flagged if peers report a different year
Client figures for the chosen KPIs	The client side of every comparison	Financial statements or KPI values, with currency and units
Data-use confirmation	Confirms the client may share the data and agrees how we use it	Required before processing

6.2 Optional

Input	What it adds	Package
Business units, sites or prior years	Enables internal benchmarking	MVP
Targets or budget	Compares plans with peer reality	MVP
Named competitors	Public-data comparison with specific rivals	Premium
Practice questionnaire	Basis for practice benchmarking	Premium
Internal reports (PDF)	Context; each figure cited to its page and confirmed	MVP
Preferred language and format	Output in PDF or Word; deck in Premium	MVP

Client figures are checked for internal consistency before use: for example, a gross margin above 100% or a period that does not match the statements stops the run.

7. Agent outputs: the exact report format

7.1 Report structure

Cover and document control	Client, sector, peer group, period, data cut-off, sources
1. Executive summary	Overall position, top three strengths, top three gaps
2. Peer group definition	Criteria, number of peers, data sources and dates
3. KPI scorecard	One row per KPI (format in 7.2)
4. Gap analysis	Gaps ranked by size and, where computable, by value
5. Interpretation by KPI family	What drives each gap, in plain language
6. Recommendations and targets	Targets at peer median and top quartile; actions
7. Method and limitations	Definitions, adjustments, what the data cannot show
Appendix	Full source list; data file (Excel)

7.2 KPI scorecard format

Column	Content
KPI and definition	Name, formula and whether higher or lower is better
Client value	From client data, with period and unit
Peer P25 / median / P75	Lower quartile, median and upper quartile of the peer group
Client position	Quartile and approximate percentile
Gap	Distance to the median and to the top quartile
Peer count (n)	Number of peers behind the figure
Source and date	Publisher, link and edition of the peer data

Illustrative layout only. No real data.

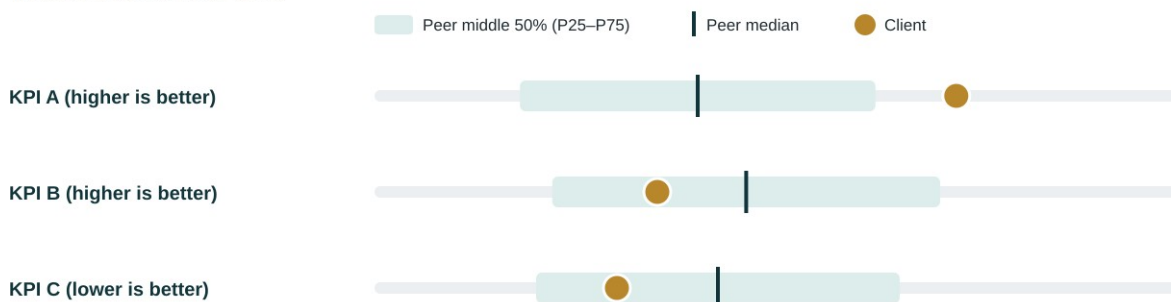


Figure 2. How each KPI is visualised in the report (layout only)

7.3 Output rules

- Every external number shows its source, date and peer count.
- Client figures, published reference levels and analyst estimates are labelled differently.
- Currency and period adjustments are stated next to the figure.

- A KPI with too few peers is withheld and the reason is given.
- Recommendations are presented as analysis and cite the evidence behind them.

8. How the agent works

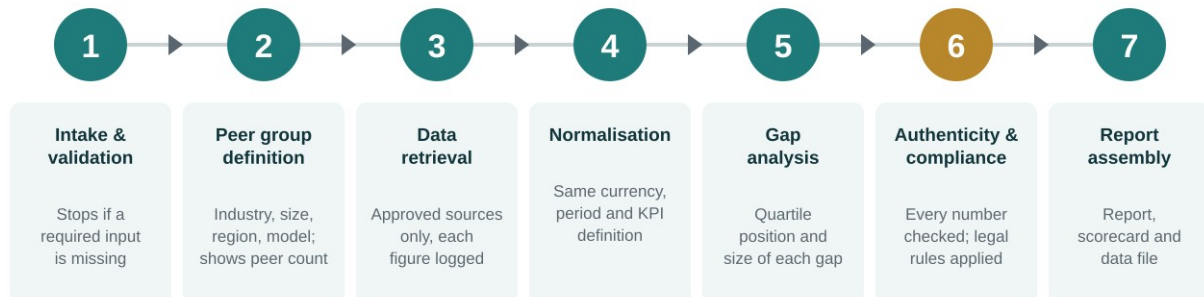


Figure 3. The seven-step workflow

Step	What happens
1. Intake and validation	Collects mandatory inputs, checks client figures for consistency, stops if anything is missing
2. Peer group definition	Applies industry, size, region and model rules; shows the peer count to the client
3. Data retrieval	Pulls figures only from the approved source list (Section 9); logs source and date for each
4. Normalisation	Puts client and peer data on the same currency, period and KPI definition
5. Gap analysis	Calculates quartile position and gap size for every KPI
6. Authenticity and compliance checks	Matches every number in the text to the data log; applies the legal rules in Section 10
7. Report assembly	Produces the report, scorecard and data file; analyst sign-off before release

Research on large language models in finance shows they can misreport numerical values, and that retrieving data from external sources and using calculation tools reduces this [42]. That is why figures in the agent come only from the data log and calculations run in code, while the language model writes the explanation.

9. Data sources

Only sources on this list may supply peer figures. Licensing terms must be confirmed for each licensed or published report before automated use (open point in Section 14).

Source	What it provides	Access	Use
SEC Financial Statement Data Sets	Financial statement data of US-listed companies from XBRL filings, quarterly since 2009 [27]	Free	MVP
Census Quarterly Financial Report	Income statements, balance sheets and ratios by industry and asset size [25]	Free	MVP
Census AIES and retail surveys	Annual revenues, expenses and assets; retail sales, inventories, e-commerce [26][17]	Free	MVP
Eurostat structural business statistics	Productivity and operating rates by NACE sector [29]	Free	MVP
World Bank Enterprise Surveys	Firm-level surveys in 154 economies (as of 2023), 100+ indicators [30]	Free (registration for firm-level data)	MVP
Damodaran industry datasets	Margins and multiples by industry (January 2026 update) [28]	Free	MVP
RMA Annual Statement Studies	19 ratios, 640+ industries, by size, from 182,000+ statements [24]	Paid licence	MVP or Premium
APQC Open Standards Benchmarking	2,000+ process measures across industries [23]	Membership or fee	Premium
SaaS benchmark reports	KeyBanc/Sapphire [11], SaaS Capital [12], Benchmarkit [13]	Free to read; terms to check	MVP (SaaS)
Sector bodies	NRF retail security survey [16]; Baymard [18]; MESA [21]	Published	Reference levels
Client data	Statements, KPIs, internal reports	Provided by client	All

10. Legal and compliance guardrails

Benchmarking touches competition law because it compares firms in the same market. The research points to four facts the product must respect.

Finding	Source
The Benchmarking Code of Conduct sets principles of legality, exchange, confidentiality and use. It warns against discussing prices or costs that feed into pricing with competitors, and against acquiring trade secrets improperly	[5]
On 11 December 2024 the US FTC and DOJ withdrew their 2000 guidelines on collaborations among competitors, removing the earlier "safety zones". In February 2026 they asked for public comment on new guidance, including on information sharing and algorithmic pricing	[7][8]
The EU's 2023 Horizontal Guidelines treat prices, quantities, capacity, customers and future plans as competitively sensitive. Shared data should be aggregated so that no firm's data can be extracted; older data is generally less sensitive, judged case by case	[9]
Under the DOJ's November 2025 settlement with RealPage, live recommendations may use only a firm's own data and public information; non-public competitor data may be used for model training only if at least 12 months old, and not at a level narrower than a state	[10]

Rules for the agent

1. Peer figures come only from public, official or properly licensed aggregated sources, plus the client's own data.
2. One client's confidential data is never used in another client's benchmark. Any future pooled peer database needs its own legal design (aggregation, minimum peer count, data age).
3. No forward-looking competitor information (prices, plans, capacity) is collected or shown.
4. The agent gives no price recommendations based on competitor data.
5. Legal review is required in each launch country before the first client report.

11. Deliverables structure: MVP versus Premium

Eric Ries defines a minimum viable product as the version that "allows a team to collect the maximum amount of validated learning about customers with the least effort" [40]. The MVP below is therefore the smallest offer that tests whether clients value and pay for sourced peer benchmarking. Packaging follows Simon-Kucher's "leaders, fillers and killers" logic: build each tier around the feature clients most want to pay for, and keep features that put buyers off out of the entry tier [41].

Feature	MVP	Premium
Performance benchmarking vs industry peer group	✓	✓
Internal benchmarking (units, sites, years)	✓	✓
Sectors: retail, SaaS, manufacturing + core financials	✓	✓
KPI scorecard with quartiles, peer count and sources	✓	✓
Gap analysis and targets (median, top quartile)	✓	✓
Report (PDF or Word) and data file (Excel)	✓	✓
Named-competitor comparison from public data	–	✓
Practice benchmarking (functional and generic)	–	✓
Finer peer segmentation (sub-sector, business model)	Basic	✓
Multi-year trend (3 or more years)	Current year	✓
Presentation deck for leadership	–	✓
Periodic refresh (for example quarterly)	–	✓
Analyst review session with the client	–	✓

11.1 Market price reference points

These are published price points for comparable products. They show that clients pay for benchmarking at every level, from free tools to enterprise programmes. They are references for pricing tests, not our prices.

Offer	Published price	Source
Xero Industry Benchmarks (small businesses)	Included in the accounting subscription	[36]
SaaS benchmark reports (KeyBanc/Sapphire, SaaS Capital, Benchmarkit)	Free	[11][12][13]
RMA Annual Statement Studies 2025–26	\$610 list; \$410 members	[24]

Offer	Published price	Source
Similarweb Starter / Professional (one user)	\$125 / \$333 per month, billed yearly	[33]
APQC Open Standards Benchmarking, non-members	Up to \$5,000 per survey	[23]
Crayon or Klue competitive intelligence	About \$20,000–40,000 per year (third-party estimate)	[34]
The Hackett Group, Gartner benchmarking	Enterprise; price on request	[31][32]

Pricing hypotheses to test in the pilot

- **MVP:** a one-off report, priced above free tools and data books but well below a consortium survey fee.
- **Premium:** an annual subscription with refresh, priced below dedicated competitive-intelligence platforms.
- Test willingness to pay with pilot clients before fixing prices, as the MVP principle requires [40][41].

12. Commercial viability

Factor	Evidence	Implication
Demand	Paid benchmarking exists at every scale, from data books to enterprise programmes [23][24][31][33]	Clients already pay for benchmarking
Commoditisation	Xero now includes industry benchmarks for small businesses [36]; free SaaS reports are widely available [11][12][13]	Raw ratios alone will not sell; interpretation and action must
Data cost	Strong free official sources exist [25][26][27][29]; deeper data is licensed [23][24]	MVP on free official data keeps cost low; licences in Premium
Legal risk	No US safe harbours since December 2024; scrutiny of data-driven tools [7][8][10]	Guardrails in Section 10 are a launch condition
Accuracy risk	Language models can misreport numbers [42]	Numbers from data and code only; analyst sign-off

Assessment

Viable, on three conditions: the offer differentiates on peer-group quality, sector KPIs and actionable interpretation rather than on raw ratios; the MVP runs mainly on free official data; and the legal guardrails are reviewed before the first client report.

13. Success metrics and release criteria

MVP release criteria

Criterion	Target
External figures in reports with source, date and peer count	100%
Numbers in the text that match the data log	100%
Runs with a missing mandatory input stopped before analysis	100%
Legal review completed for each launch country	Before first client report
Analyst sign-off on every pilot report	100%

Business metrics to track in the pilot

Pilot-to-paid conversion, MVP-to-Premium upgrade rate, repeat purchase, and client rating of report usefulness. Numeric targets are set after the first pilot cohort, once there is a baseline.

14. Risks, assumptions and open questions

Risks

Risk	Mitigation
Peer data too thin for a small sector or country	Show peer count; fall back to wider region or published reference levels, labelled
Different KPI definitions between sources	Written definitions per KPI; normalisation step; adjustments disclosed
Licence terms forbid automated use of a source	Licence check before a source is added to the approved list
Competition-law exposure	Rules in Section 10; legal review per country
Free tools erode the entry market	Differentiate on interpretation, sector depth and action plan

Assumptions (to confirm)

- Target clients range from small businesses to mid-market firms. Client size mix is not yet confirmed.
- Clients can supply financial statements or KPI values for the chosen period.
- The Macroeconomy Agent's verified exchange-rate and inflation data can be reused.

Open questions

Question	Owner	Needed by
Which countries launch first?	Management	Architecture start

Question	Owner	Needed by
Minimum peer count for publishing a benchmark	Product + Legal	Architecture
Which licensed sources to buy for Premium	Product + Finance	Premium build
Pilot clients and pricing test design	Commercial	Before pilot
Who signs off each report	Management	Before pilot

Appendix A. KPI definitions used in this document

Term	Meaning
Benchmark	A reference value from a peer group or published standard, used for comparison
Peer group	The set of comparable organisations the client is compared with
Median, P25, P75	The middle value of the peer group, and the values a quarter of the way up and three quarters of the way up
Quartile	One of four equal parts of the peer group, ranked from lowest to highest
Top quartile	The best-performing quarter of peers; used as the stretch target, following Hackett's world-class definition [31]
NAICS / NACE	Official industry classification systems used in North America and the EU
ARR	Annual recurring revenue from subscriptions
NRR / GRR	Net and gross revenue retention (Section 5.4)
GMROI	Gross margin return on inventory investment (Section 5.3)
OEE	Overall equipment effectiveness (Section 5.5)

Appendix B. References

Sources were reviewed on 1–2 October 2026. Figures quoted from secondary reports and price estimates are marked as such in the text. The structure of this PRD follows common practice: Cagan's purpose, features and release criteria [37], Atlassian's assumptions, open questions and out-of-scope sections [38], and explicit non-goals [39].

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